

Food for Thought 1: Navigation AI Together

Executive Summary

This session presented baseline survey results comparing faculty (N=155) and student (N=107) perspectives on AI use in academic settings, followed by facilitated discussion.

Key Survey Findings

Adoption rates are nearly symmetrical: while about half use AI regularly, about 20% of each group has never used AI tools. Both groups identify primarily as intermediate users and request pedagogical support rather than technical training. Faculty want guidance on ethics and academic integrity; students want clear policies from instructors. The survey's small sample sizes and self-selection bias, especially among students, should be considered when interpreting these findings.

One-third of surveyed students reported being against AI use in their academic work, compared to 11% of faculty. Session participants debated whether this reflects genuine concern about learning, fear of ambiguous policies, or survey response bias. Several faculty expressed skepticism, noting their experience of students using AI while claiming otherwise.

Faculty reported spending significant time verifying AI-generated references that turned out to be fabricated. A few noted they could detect AI-generated work but felt unable to confront students without definitive proof. Some faculty advocated for minimizing prosecution and policing of students, while a minority expressed frustration at lacking clear misconduct procedures. The room largely agreed that a university-wide policy would be impractical given disciplinary differences.

Multiple faculty doubted students' self-reported concern about AI accuracy, noting that in practice, students often accept AI output without verification. One participant wrote: "students are not transparent about how they use AI... they don't want to accept it in a survey distributed by faculty".

Students want explicit policies; faculty want guidance on what those policies should contain. Several faculty admitted uncertainty in drafting their own AI policies, with one noting they would benefit from knowing how students actually want to use AI. A participant observed that writing-intensive course syllabi often lack explicit AI policies.

Discussion

Faculty expressed concern that AI may cheat students of learning by allowing them to skip foundational skill-building. The question was raised: if solving a problem demonstrates understanding, what does AI-assisted problem-solving demonstrate? Counter-perspectives noted that AI could reduce busywork, freeing time for deeper human engagement.

Some argued students must know AI to be successful. They highlighted the optimism of broader AI adoption among faculty and students as it would allow them to do more important human work. Others cautioned that students arrive with AI habits that are not necessarily robust, requiring education on responsible use. A few suggested the goal should be persuading students *not* to use AI, reinforcing that foundational education matters regardless of perceived course relevance to their careers.

One participant noted AI provides stress relief because "[we induce stress by putting too much weight on grades]". Others observed reduced office hour traffic.

One senior faculty member shared that AI may propel them toward early retirement despite loving their work. Conversely, another faculty shared that some of their students reportedly view professors who lean heavily on AI as "a joke". Some faculty stated they would never offload grading to AI because direct engagement with student work is how they track learning.

Some faculty said they would make AI policies more specific and explicit, address AI expectations in class, and incorporate student input. Others suggested experimenting with different AI integration methods and asking students for breakdowns of their contributions in assignments.